

BETWEEN PROMISE AND PRECARITY, A NEW SEASON BECKONS

As Indian hockey prepares for a **decisive build-up** to 2026, the Hockey India League resumes as both a proving ground and a measure of the sport's fragile recovery.

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A new schedule, new teams and new owners: the second edition of the revived Hockey India League (HIL) will have all of this and more when it finally gets underway on January 3 (December 28 for the women). It marks the beginning of what is expected to be a long, hectic and crucial year in the overall scheme of things for Indian hockey.

It has been an unusually long



Podium finish: Shrachi Rarh Bengal Tigers defeated Hyderabad Toofans 4-3 in the final at the Birsa Munda International Hockey Stadium in Rourkela to win the 2024-25 season. THE HINDU PHOTO LIBRARY

break for the men's national team, which has not played at full strength in a major competition since clinching the Asia Cup and a World Cup spot in Rajgir in September. The few international outings since then, an India A tour of China, the Sultan Azlan Shah Cup and a short trip to South Africa, have been more experimental than competitive, testing youngsters and new combinations with an eye on 2026, when the World Cup and the Asian Games will take centre stage. That process will continue at the HIL, with coach Craig Fulton keeping a close watch not only on his core group but also on the juniors who finished with bronze at the Junior World Cup recently and are expected to step up to the senior level sooner rather than later.

The build-up, however, has been anything but smooth. While it was always understood that Team Gonasika had stepped in as the eighth men's team last year as a stop-gap arrangement, the

withdrawal of the Singhanian-backed UP Rudras and Odisha Warriors from the women's competition just before the mini-auction earlier this year was a major setback. It raised questions over the financial viability and stability of the league. Ranchi Royals replaced the Odisha teams, while Hockey India had to step in and take charge of the UP side, rechristening it as the HIL Governing Council team. Even among the remaining franchises, several raised economic concerns and struggled to clear player dues in 2025, including men's champion Shrachi Bengal Tigers, with the federation eventually using prize money to settle payments.

Indian women's hockey, meanwhile, has endured a difficult few weeks, and it remains to be seen how players return to action after everything that has unfolded off the field. Like the men, the women's team has not played competitively since the Asia Cup in September, but there has been no shortage of developments away from the pitch.